example of chain letters. With the number of available atoms, this chain reaction may reach quite enormous, hardly conceivable proportions. Of course, an indispensable prerequisite for this effect is that the free neutrons, prior to their hitting uranium nuclei, are not captured by other atoms and are thus either permanently absorbed by the latter or deflected away from uranium nuclei.

A specific computation has shown that the amount of energy released in this manner in a cubic meter (35.314 cubic feet) of powdered uranium oxide within one one-hundredth of second is sufficient to lift a weight of 1,000,000,-000 metric tons to a height of almost 17 miles. This amount of energy could replace the output of all the big power plants of the world combined for many years.

Up to quite recently, a technical utilization of the energy latent in the nuclei of atoms might have appeared as a utopian dream. But it was made a reality about 1942, by the impressive collaboration of British and American scientists with American industry, backed by huge government subsidies. At the present moment, several “uranium piles” are operating in America, and the heat continually produced by them is sufficient to raise the temperature of the Victoria River in the state of Washington by 1 degree Centigrade. So far as the reports disclose, these vast amounts of energy are still unused. Right now, the problem is to get rid of them in a harmless way. But these same piles furnish also the raw materials for the atomic bombs, in which vast amounts of the nuclear energy of the atom are liberated within a fraction of a second, producing explosions beside which the devastation caused by all chemical explosives fades into insignificance. No words can be strong enough to over-emphasize the danger of self-extermination which threatens the entire human race, should a future war bring about the use of a large number of such bombs. Human imagination is incapable of conceiving the possible consequences. A particularly eloquent and forceful plea for peace is the memory of the 80,000 dead of Hiroshima and the 40,000 dead of Nagasaki, a plea addressed to all nations, and especially to their responsible leaders.

In view of these facts, perhaps many who have lost the art of wondering may feel disposed to learn it anew. And in fact, compared with immeasurably rich, ever young Nature, advanced as man may be in scientific knowledge and insight, he must forever remain the wondering child and must constantly be prepared for new surprises.

Thus we see ourselves governed all through life by a higher power, whose nature we shall never be able to define from the viewpoint of exact science. Yet, no one who thinks can ignore it. A thinking human being, who has not only scientific but also metaphysical interests, must choose one of two possible attitudes: Either fear and hostile resistance or reverence and trusting devotion. If we reflect on all the unspeakable suffering and incessant